

# Meeting Summaries of November 6, 2025

**Date:** November 6, 2025

**Time:** 1:00–1:45 PM(PDT)

**Attendees:** Prof. Jan, Dr. Javed, Dr. Yue and Feng

**Topic:** Feng's report on the progress of reproduced work and inquiry of advice about application and reference letters

## Summary of Discussion

- Feng reported the progress that has reached to completeness of sediment contamination assessment. The major focuses in this process were about:
  - Exploratory data analysis to understand the data distribution and correlations among variables. Transform and standardize the data to be used in the model, check the general spatial patterns that might hidden in the data.
  - Explaining the rationals of adapting the specific transformation methods, how they fit our views and assumptions from machanistic perspectives.
  - An easier way to explain the PCA results by hierarchical clustering on the PCA scores, which group the raw variables based on their similarities in the PC space.
  - Assumption on ecotoxicological harmness of selected PCs, transform their scores to fit this assumption accordingly.
- Feng required advices about school list to apply and reference letters support from Prof. Jan and Dr. Javed and Dr. Yue. Prof. Jan and Dr. Javed gave some detailed suggestions:
  - Make priorities among the schools, focus on the top and closest (in time) one first, prepare the materials as if this is the only one to apply (Prof. Jan).
  - Send Feng's CV, undergraduate and graduate transcripts to Prof. Jan, Dr. Javed and Dr. Yue to help them write reference letters clearer (Dr. Javed).
  - If the school requaires a statement of research interests or research proposal, Feng should also send this to professors to help them understand Feng's research interests better (Prof. Jan).
  - Different institutions have different advantages in terms of research fields, Feng should check it and prepare materials accordingly (Dr. Javed).
  - The number of application shoools should be controlled around 5 to 6, focus on quality rather than quantity (Dr. Javed).
  - It needs to check the deadlines of reference letters for each school, at least 7 days should be given to professors to write the letters (Prof. Jan and Dr. Javed).

## Action items

- Feng will finish the last step in computing the contamination scores, and deliver the stage results to next stage of clustering analysis and discriminant function analysis.
- Feng is gonna prepare the application for UBC right after the meeting. It is a high preferred school and the deadline is coming soon - (submission due on Dec 1; reference letters due on Dec 15).

## **Follow-Up**

Temporary meeting time: 1:00–1:40 PM (PDT), November 27

## **Supportive materials**

- A meeting recording with subtitles has been stored in Feng's laptop.